

Weekly Reading Reflections #1: Sergio Monterroso

Producing Heritage & Les Lieux de Mémoire

Producing Heritage

The discussion of heritage being a process of ever-evolving change was an interesting concept that confronted my previous view on heritage in-general. Previously, I was under the assumption that heritage was an immovable object dictated by the past as a certain group understood it, typically on a romanticized view that painted the group viewing the heritage in a better light. Native American heritage cherishes war leaders despite them being painfully outgunned by their English counterparts, and, drawing back on our in-class discussion on the Lost Cause, Confederacy heritage also paints soldiers of the South as being virtuous heroes despite fighting for a grotesque cause.

The main takeaway I got from the heritage articles, and the discussion we had on them in class, was the definition of heritage that we're going to be using for this class, that is: the use of history as a story-telling device to affect our actions of the present. Graham and the other authors defined heritage differently in a more superficial way, but they did introduce the idea of "future heritage" in their definition. I took this "future heritage" to involve taking the present (which is affected by the past) and projecting it on the future, which seems correct based on the article's view (Page 2). They also expanded more on how heritage, as a process, is not just the past but being employed in the present/future, but that it's also the present creating the past to use it for the present.

Taking into consideration how Graham characterizes heritage as being crafted by the present through elements (whether "true" or "untrue", and I realize how much that word should be avoided in this class) of the past, I turn back towards the Laurajane article on how Heritage is a discourse *because* it is crafted by the present. In one example, Laurajane gives an example of this discourse by saying that heritage can be "about reworking the meanings of the past as the cultural, social, and political needs of the present change or develop." (Page 4). This is one motive that "the present" can change meanings of heritage as a story. The discussion of this class will later evolve into pondering about who is "the present" and how/why do they change heritage.

Les Lieux de Mémoire

Pierre Nora's idea of memory builds on the ideas of heritage being a concept that is constantly being redefined by the present. For the rest of the reflection, memory and heritage are essentially interchangeable. Memory, as per Nora, is held by groups and is always changing to give us Geschichte (story). His conclusion here is that heritage has a story and emotional ties to the present, otherwise we wouldn't use it. He then warns against the historiographical analysis of memory because it leads to a lifeless view of history. His proof of this is the expansion and rise of archive-memory, where people are working to mass-archive everything to historical (memory) record because it doesn't do so on its own (because everything is so analytical). This is duty-memory, although it's best characterized as just history.

I don't mean for this section to just be me summarizing Nora's article, but it was, admittedly, a tough read that requires me to do so in-order for me to connect it with the course content and objectives.

Nora frames the relationship of memory as history like our discussion between the AHD and "unauthorized" historical discourse. Heritage is memory of the past to the group remembering it and so it is responsive to censorship or "unauthorization" while History is methodologically bound to historiography which seeks to procure "true" memory, which "enlarge the basis for a collective memory." In light of this, Nora praises the lieux de mémoire, which are physical sites or objects that have significant memory (his term) attached to it, such as a French battlefield which empowers a national sense of identity.

Nora points out that today's history is like looking at a building from the exterior scaffolding and outward signs, purely archival and distant. I think it's important to note what is being archived today, and it's the personals of everyone. Nora even acknowledges this, noting that main archivists in the past were "great families, the church, and the state" but today it is anyone. I disagree immensely and even Nora works against his point. History archival is no different in this era as to others, except with the added caveat that *everyone* is archiving because they have the newfound ability to do so. They are archiving their thoughts, their lives, and their stories. Each archival is its own *Geschichte* and serves Nora's definition of memory, as an extension of heritage being passed down with emotional sense attached to it.

I don't like Nora.

Parting Notes

This is my first reflection assignment for Dr. Hightower, so I am not knowledgeable about whether this assignment is formal, informal, or a mixture of the two. On this paper, I went with a mixture to maintain professional discussion while also proverbially vomiting my reflections on the readings, how they connect with other parts of the course, and how they affect my final project.